



ENGLISH GRAMMAR

Appositives & Reduced Adverb Clauses

A Complete Guide for Intermediate Learners

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01 | WHAT IS AN APPOSITIVE?

 An appositive is a noun or noun phrase that sits next to another noun to rename it or describe it in another way.



Function

Renames or re-describes the noun right next to it — giving extra information.



Form

A noun, a pronoun, or a full noun phrase (e.g., 'my dog', 'the best player').



Punctuation

Set off with commas ,__, parentheses = round brackets (__) or dashes - ____ - from the rest.

02 | APPOSITIVES: Offset with COMMAS

NOUN , APPOSITIVE , rest of sentence

appositive

"my dog"

Dexter, my dog, will chew your shoes if you leave them there.

appositive

"my Army mate"

Lee, my Army mate, caught a whelk while fishing for bass.

appositive

"the creator of the turnip brew"

Dr. Pat, the creator of the turnip brew, sold 8 barrels on the first day.

02 | APPOSITIVES: Parentheses & Dashes

() Parentheses / Round Brackets

NOUN (APPOSITIVE) rest

Peter (my mate from school) won the lottery.



When to use:

Use parentheses when the appositive info is extra or less important — it's a 'side note' to the reader.

– – Dashes (Em Dash)

NOUN – APPOSITIVE – rest

Prices in Alton – a small town only 25 minutes from London – have been soaring.



When to use:

Use dashes to make the appositive stand out with more dramatic emphasis than commas.

03 | WHAT IS A REDUCED ADVERB CLAUSE?



Like reduced relative clauses, reduced adverb clauses give more emphasis and are used when BOTH clauses share the SAME subject.

HOW IT WORKS — Three-step reduction:

STEP 1

Full adverb clause

While I was walking down the beach, I saw a dolphin stranded.

STEP 2

Remove subject + BE

While walking down the beach, I saw a dolphin stranded.

STEP 3

Can also drop connector

Walking down the beach, I saw a dolphin stranded.



04 | TIME CLAUSES — While, Before, After, Since, Until

RULE: Time conjunctions (While/Before/After/Since/Until) are NEVER omitted when reducing.

Connect or	FULL ADVERB CLAUSE	REDUCED FORM
Before	Before I came to class, I had a cup of coffee.	Before coming to class, I had a cup of coffee.
Since	Since Bahodir came here, he has learnt English a lot.	Since coming here, Bahodir has learnt English a lot.
After	After she had finished her shopping, she went home.	After finishing her shopping, she went home.
Until	All the old museums must be renovated until they are opened for public again.	All museums must be renovated until opened for public again.



05 | SPECIAL CASE: Subject Shift (SPETION)

Sometimes the subject in the adverb clause is a general 'one' or differs from the main subject. When reducing, the pronoun changes to match the new gerund phrase.

Full: One should always check a contract before he signs it.

Reduced: One should always check a contract before signing it.

→ The pronoun 'he' shifts to the gerund 'signing' — no subject needed in the reduced form.

Full: Before I came to class, I had a cup of coffee.

Reduced: Before coming to class, I had a cup of coffee.

→ Same subject 'I' in both clauses — standard reduction. Conjunction 'before' stays.



06 | SPECIAL CASE: 'WHEN' → on/upon + V-ing

Instead of **'when + clause'** we can use **on / upon + V-ing** to reduce the sentence.

Full Clause: **When Sandra graduated from university, she applied for a job.**

Reduced: **On / upon graduating from university, she applied for a job.**

NOTE: In passive sentences or when 'to be' is the main verb — omit the subject AND 'be'.

When he was a little boy, he was very naughty.

→ **When a little boy, he was very naughty.**

When they are used too often, words may lose their value.

→ **When used too often, words may lose their value.**

When you are walking alone at night, be careful.

→ **When walking alone at night, be careful.**

07 | ACTIVE vs PASSIVE REDUCTION — Quick Reference

VOICE	ORIGINAL	HOW TO REDUCE	RESULT
ACTIVE	S + connector + is/are + V-ing + ...	Remove subject + BE	connector + V-ing
PASSIVE	S + connector + is/are/was + V3 ...	Remove subject + BE	connector + V3
PASSIVE (to be)	When S + is/was + NOUN/ADJ ...	Remove subject + BE entirely	When + NOUN /ADJ



TIME connectors (never omitted): While · After · Before · Since · Until

CAUSE connectors (can be dropped): Because · As · Since



QUIZ 1 | Identify the Appositive

Underline the appositive in each sentence and state the punctuation used (commas / parentheses / dashes).

1. My sister, the brilliant engineer, just got promoted.

2. Tom (my neighbor from Ohio) baked this cake.

3. The Amazon – the world's largest river – runs through Brazil.

4. Our teacher, Mr. Grant, gave us extra homework.

5. Paris, the capital of France, is known as the City of Light.

QUIZ 1 | ANSWERS

"the brilliant engineer"

→ Set off with two commas on each side.

COMMAS

"my neighbor from Ohio"

→ Enclosed in round brackets — extra info.

PARENTHESES

"the world's largest river"

→ Set off with em dashes — emphatic.

DASHES

"Mr. Grant"

→ Single-word appositive, offset with commas.

COMMAS

"the capital of France"

→ Descriptive noun phrase, offset with commas.

COMMAS



QUIZ 2 | Reduce the Adverb Clause

Rewrite each sentence with a reduced adverb clause. Keep the conjunction if needed.

1. While she was waiting for the bus, she read a book.

2. Before he left the house, he checked all the windows.

3. After they had finished dinner, they watched a movie.

4. Since he moved to this city, he has made many friends.

5. When Sandra graduated from university, she applied for a job.

QUIZ 2 | ANSWERS

While waiting for the bus, she read a book.

→ 'While' kept. 'she was' removed → V-ing.

Before leaving the house, he checked all the windows.

→ 'Before' kept. 'he' removed → V-ing.

After finishing dinner, they watched a movie.

→ 'After' kept. 'they had' removed → V-ing.

Since moving to this city, he has made many friends.

→ 'Since' kept. 'he' removed → V-ing.

On/Upon graduating from university, she applied for a job.

→ 'When' → 'On/Upon' + V-ing.

QUIZ 3 | Mixed: Appositives + Reduced Adverb Clauses

Decide: Is each sentence correct? If not, correct it.

1. Alex my best friend came first in the race.

2. While watching the game, we ate popcorn.

3. Before to leave the office, she sent all the emails.

4. The Eiffel Tower – a famous landmark in Paris – was built in 1889.

5. Since she came to London she has visited many museums.

QUIZ 3 | ANSWERS

X WRONG

Alex, my best friend, came first in the race.

Appositive 'my best friend' needs commas on both sides.

✓ CORRECT

While watching the game, we ate popcorn.

Correct active reduction: 'we were watching' → 'watching'.

X WRONG

Before leaving the office, she sent all the emails.

After 'before', use V-ing, not 'to + verb'.

✓ CORRECT

The Eiffel Tower – a famous landmark... – was built...

Correct use of dashes for an appositive with internal commas.

X WRONG

Since coming to London, she has visited many museums.

'Since' kept. Subject removed → 'coming'. Add comma after clause.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

Appositives & Reduced Adverb Clauses



Appositives rename/describe a noun — offset with commas, (), or —



Time connectors (While/Before/After/Since/Until) STAY when reducing



Active reduction → V-ing | Passive reduction → V3 (past participle)



Both clauses must share the SAME SUBJECT for reduction to be possible

Great work! Keep practicing and these will feel natural. 🌿